

Challenge Write-Up Template

Challenge Information

Student Name	Pascua, Diana KC S.
Section / Class	BSIT-3G
Challenge Name	Printer Shares
Category	General Skills
Points / Difficulty	Easy
Date Solved	8/16/26
Flag Format Given	picoCTF{....}

1. Challenge Description

I did a challenge from picoCTF called "Printer Shares,". This time I wasn't given a file to download instead I was given a server address and a port number, and I had to connect to it myself. There were also two hints telling me it had something to do with the SMB protocol, and that smbclient and smbutil would be useful tools. My goal was to connect to the server, find a way into whatever it was sharing, and dig out a flag in the format picoCTF{...}.

2. Initial Analysis / Reconnaissance

The first thing I did was just make sure the host and port I was given were actually reachable, so I ran nc -vz on the address and port. It connected successfully, which told me there really was something listening there. Since the hints pointed straight at SMB and smbclient, I didn't have to guess much about the category this was clearly a networking challenge about SMB file shares, specifically about a share that had been set up to allow guest/anonymous access (no username or password needed).

3. Tools and Commands Used

List every tool/command you used, in the order you used them, and what each one told you.

Tool / Command	What it was used for	Result / Output
nc -vz mysterious-sea.picoctf.net 64046	Checked if the given host/port was open before trying anything else.	Connection succeeded, so I knew a service was actually listening on that port.
smbclient//mysterious-sea.picoctf.net 64046 -N	Listed the available SMB shares on the server, connecting as a guest (-N = no password)	Showed two shares: "shares" (a Disk share described as "Public Share With Guests") and the default IPC\$ share
smbclient//mysterious-sea.picoctf.net/shares -p 64046 -N	Connected into the "shares" share as a guest to browse its files	Dropped me into an interactive smb: \> prompt
Ls (inside smbclient)	Listed the files sitting inside the shares folder	Showed two files dummy.txt and flag.txt
Get flag.txt	Downloaded flag.txt from the share to my local machine	File transferred successfully(37 bytes)
Cat flag.txt	Printed the contents of the downloaded file	picoCTF{.....}

4. Solution Walkthrough

Step 1

Confirm the port is open

I ran `nc -vz mysterious-sea.picoctf.net 64046` first, just to check the port was actually open before I tried any SMB-specific tools. It said the connection succeeded, so I knew the next step made sense.

Step 2

List the available shares

I ran `smbclient -L //mysterious-sea.picoctf.net -p 64046 -N`. The `-L` flag lists shares instead of connecting to one, and `-N` tells it not to prompt for a password (anonymous/guest login). The output showed a share literally called "shares," described as a "Public Share With Guests" that description basically confirmed guest access was allowed, so I didn't need any credentials.

Step 3

Connect to the share and look around

I connected directly into it with `smbclient //mysterious-sea.picoctf.net/shares -p 64046 -N`, which dropped me into an `smb: \>` prompt, kind of like an FTP session. I ran `ls` and saw two files sitting there: `dummy.txt` and `flag.txt`. The name `flag.txt` was obviously the one I wanted.

Step 4

Download the flag and read it

I typed `get flag.txt` to pull the file down to my own machine, then `exit` to leave the SMB session. Back at my normal terminal, I ran `cat flag.txt` and it printed the flag straight away: `picoCTF{5mb_pr1nter_5h4re5_8caa47ce}`. No exploit or password cracking was needed — the whole challenge was really about knowing that SMB shares can be configured to allow anonymous browsing, and knowing the right commands to list and pull files from one.

Printer Shares

General Skills

Easy

by Janice He · picoCTF 2026

Launch Instance

Additional details appear once you launch your instance.

HINTS

- 1 knowing how SMB protocol works would be helpful!
- 2 smbclient and smbutil are good tools

FLAG

picoCTF{5mb_prINTER_5h4re5_8caa47ce}

Submit

Correct flag!

checked by typing `usage`.

Idle sessions will automatically log out after 15 minutes.

For more information and a beginner's guide, type `less ~/README.txt`.

```
PascuaDiana-academy@webshell:~$ nc -vz mysterious-sea.picoctf.net 64046
Connection to mysterious-sea.picoctf.net (3.130.79.223) 64046 port [tcp/*] succeeded!
PascuaDiana-academy@webshell:~$ smbclient -L //mysterious-sea.picoctf.net -p 64046 -N
```

Sharename	Type	Comment
-----	----	-----
shares	Disk	Public Share With Guests
IPC\$	IPC	IPC Service (Samba 4.19.5-Ubuntu)

SMB1 disabled -- no workgroup available

```
PascuaDiana-academy@webshell:~$ smbclient //mysterious-sea.picoctf.net/shares -p 64046 -N
Try "help" to get a list of possible commands.
```

```
smb: \> ls
.                D           0   Fri Mar  6 20:25:39 2026
..               D           0   Fri Mar  6 20:25:39 2026
dummy.txt        N        1142 Wed Feb  4 21:22:17 2026
flag.txt         N          37  Fri Mar  6 20:25:39 2026
```

65536 blocks of size 1024. 58232 blocks available

```
smb: \> get flag.txt
getting file \flag.txt of size 37 as flag.txt (9.0 KiloBytes/sec) (average 9.0 KiloBytes/sec)
smb: \> exit
```

```
PascuaDiana-academy@webshell:~$ cat flag.txt
picoCTF{5mb_prINTER_5h4re5_8caa47ce}
PascuaDiana-academy@webshell:~$
```

5. Flag

`picoCTF{5mb_pr1nter_5h4re5_8caa47ce}`

6. Key Concept / What I Learned

This challenge was about misconfigured SMB shares that allow anonymous (guest) access. In a real network, a share like this would let anyone on the network list and download files without ever logging in, which is a serious information-disclosure risk. It taught me to always check for guest/null-session access when I come across an SMB service, since that's usually the fastest way in before trying anything more complicated.

7. References

smbclient man page (Samba documentation)
